

over absorption of sound, causing it to sound artificial and unnatural. So, ensure that you don't completely fill your room with absorbers. A budget-friendly option that some sound artists have used in their early days of recording is simply hanging up thick blankets on walls to reduce sound reflections.



PICKING THE RIGHT MICROPHONE AND SETTING IT UP

Listeners can really tell the difference between sound output from a low-quality versus high-quality microphone. Usually the best type of microphone to use for home recordings in untreated spaces is a cardioid dynamic microphone. An example is the Shure SM58. Avoid using your laptop or computer's internal microphone. They simply don't cut it for podcasts. The market is saturated with an array of great USB microphones that also work well for podcast recording. Some examples include the Blue Yeti and the HyperX Quadcast.

If you want to go a step further from USB mics, you can pick up an analogue (XLR) microphone. USB mics convert analogue sound into digital, so recording is as simple as plug-and-go, however, the audio quality could potentially be lower than that of an analogue microphone. Analogue mics use XLR connectors, so you need an XLR recorder or an audio interface to actually get the audio onto your computer but the audio quality is better. Some good examples of analogue microphones include the Shure SM7B, Audio Technica AT2035, and the budget-friendly Samson Q2U. If



The Shure SM7B

you're just starting out, you can even use your phone's recorder as long as you're in a favourable recording environment. If you own an iPhone, one trick is to set your Voice memo settings to lossless quality.

Having a good microphone means nothing if you don't set it up right. For the uninitiated, it is never a good idea to get too close to a microphone since it



Adding a pop filter to your microphone can filter out plosive sounds

riddles the audio with plosives (p and b sounds) and unnecessary mouth noises. One good practice to avoid this is placing your microphone off-axis (but still directed towards your mouth) instead of placing it directly in front of you. Instead of air hitting your microphone, it will tend to just pick up your voice this way. Also, ensure that the distance between you and your microphone is about 6 inches. You could also consider picking up a pop filter, which is typically made out of foam, mesh or metal. Pop filters dissipate the air moving towards your

microphone. So if you do have one, you can actually place your microphone on-axis, capturing your voice clearly while filtering the plosives and air.



RECORD SEPARATE CHANNELS

If you plan on hosting your podcast alone and not having guests, you can skip this one. However, most podcasts usually have guest-speakers or co-hosts that probably record from different locations. Especially during the pandemic, most collabs and guest speakers will join in on your podcast virtually. You may be tempted to record over Skype, however, sound quality actually takes a hit when voice is transmitted over the app. One voice usually tends to sound a lot better which can be distracting and polarising for your listeners. In order to counteract this, the ideal approach is to have each person record their own audio. This is termed double ender recording where both your guest and you record each end of the audio locally and they are stitched together in post-production. It is a good practice to ask your guest to record a high-quality WAV/AIFF file on their end.

There are also a variety of platforms available that allow you to record double enders remotely. Some

examples include SquadCast, Zencaster, Cleanfeed.net, RINGR, and RODEcaster Pro. If you want to go another route, you can also use Zoom since it can be set up to record each participant as a separate audio file.



KEEP THE LEVELS IN CHECK

You must aim to record your podcast with healthy input levels since it plays a major role in how the podcast will sound overall. To do this, first ensure that you don't set the input gain too low. If you record with low input gain, you will most likely have to increase the signal's level in your DAW (digital audio workstation) in post production. By doing this, you will also increase the level of noise floor (level of noise). Recording at higher input levels is preferred since it separates your voice from the noise floor within the room and also filters out the low-level hum that exists in recording equipment. However, there's a case to be made against too much input gain since it can potentially distort or even clip your input signal.

A healthy input level is around -16dB to -12dB, if you are speaking at a regular voice level into your microphone. One good practice is to notice where the levels peak when you are at your loudest and then set the input levels accordingly.



SquadCast allows you to record both ends of the conversation locally